

§ 170.315(b)(4)

Real-time prescription benefit

Certification Companion Guide 1.0

Issued Date: 09-30-2025

This Certification Companion Guide (CCG) is an informative document designed to assist with health IT product certification. The CCG is not a substitute for the requirements outlined in regulation and related ASTP/ONC final rules. It extracts key portions of ASTP/ONC final rules' preambles and includes subsequent clarifying interpretations. To access the full context of regulatory intent please consult the [Certification Program Regulations](#) page for links to all final rules or consult other regulatory references as noted. The CCG is for public use and should not be sold or redistributed.

Certification Clarifications

Technical Explanations and Clarifications

- The estimated cost information included in the RTPBRequest and RTPBResponse transactions only pertains to patient out-of-pocket costs. Prescribers using Real-Time Benefit Tools (RTBTs) that implement the NCPDP RTPB standard, version 13, have the capability to request and receive information on overall costs. This includes fields such as “estimated net plan cost” and “estimated combined plan and patient savings” but only when allowed and provided by the plan. [see also [90 FR 37154](#)]
- There are no restrictions to the scope of products included in this criterion, allowing coverage of any pharmacy benefit products (e.g., medications, vaccines, supplies, devices). [see also [90 FR 37157](#)]
- Developers must support transactions with at least one version of RxNorm.

Technical outcome – Enable a user to perform real-time prescription benefit (RTPB) requests and receive RTPB information using the XML format in accordance with the NCPDP Real-Time Prescription Benefit Standard Implementation Guide v13, RxNorm and NDC.

Clarifications:

- A Health IT Module must enable a user to use conduct transactions in accordance with one of the versions of RxNorm “at a minimum” to ensure alignment with the existing minimum standards code set policy in the Certification Program in 45 CFR 170.555. [see also [90 FR 37158](#)]
- RTPBError transactions are not a requirement under this criterion as error handling is built into the RTPBResponse transaction. [see also [90 FR 37154](#)]

STANDARDS REFERENCED

§ 170.205(c)(1)

[NCPDP Real-Time Prescription Benefit Standard Implementation Guide v13](#) [↗](#)

§ 170.207(d)(1)(i)

[RxNorm, July 5, 2022 Full Monthly Release](#) [↗](#)

§ 170.207(d)(1)(ii)

[RxNorm, December 4, 2023 Full Monthly Release](#) [↗](#)

§ 170.207(d)(1)(iii)

[RxNorm, September 8, 2015 Full Release Update](#) [↗](#)

§ 170.207(d)(2)

[National Drug Codes \(NDC\)](#) [↗](#)

Technical outcome – Display to a user in human readable format patient-specific prescription benefit information, estimated cost information, and alternative products, in accordance with the NCPDP Real-Time Prescription Benefit Standard Implementation Guide v13.

Clarifications:

- ONC previously referred to “alternative products” as “therapeutic alternatives” in earlier proposed rules. However, to be consistent with NCPDP terminology, regulation was finalized to reference “alternative products.” [see also 90 FR 37154]
- Developers have flexibility in determining how to present information to users.

STANDARDS REFERENCED

§ 170.205(c)(1)

[NCPDP Real-Time Prescription Benefit Standard Implementation Guide v13](#) [↗](#)

Regulation Text

§ 170.315 (b)(4) Real-time prescription benefit—

(i) Send and receive information.

Enable a user to perform the following transactions using the XML format in accordance with at least one of the versions of the standards adopted in § 170.205(c); at a minimum, a standard adopted in § 170.207(d)(1); and the standard in § 170.207(d)(2), as follows:

- (A) Request patient-specific prescription benefit information, estimated cost information, and alternative products, in accordance with the RTPBRequest transaction.
- (B) Receive patient-specific prescription benefit information, estimated cost information, and alternative products in response to a request, in accordance with the RTPBResponse transaction.

(ii) Display.

- (A) Display to a user in human readable format patient-specific prescription benefit information, estimated cost information, and alternative products, in accordance with at least one of the versions of the standard adopted in § 170.205(c).

Standards & References

The following standards are referenced within the certification criteria for:

§ 170.205(c)(1)

[NCPDP Real-Time Prescription Benefit Standard Implementation Guide v13](#) 

Referenced in the Following:

- Paragraph (b)(4)(i)

- Paragraph (b)(4)(ii)

§ 170.207(d)(1)(i)

[RxNorm, July 5, 2022 Full Monthly Release](#) 

Referenced in the Following:

- Paragraph (b)(4)(i)

§ 170.207(d)(1)(ii)

[RxNorm, December 4, 2023 Full Monthly Release](#) 

Referenced in the Following:

- Paragraph (b)(4)(i)

§ 170.207(d)(1)(iii)

[RxNorm, September 8, 2015 Full Release Update](#) 

Referenced in the Following:

- Paragraph (b)(4)(i)

§ 170.207(d)(2)

[National Drug Codes \(NDC\)](#) 

Referenced in the Following:

- Paragraph (b)(4)(i)

Certification Dependencies

Dependent Criteria

Any developer that obtains certification for the “electronic prescribing” certification criterion in 45 CFR 170.315(b)(3) must also obtain certification for the “real-time prescription benefit” criterion in 45 CFR 170.315(b)(4).

§ 170.405

Real World Testing

Products certified to this criterion must complete requirements outlined for the Real World Testing Conditions and Maintenance of Certification.

Design and Performance

The following design and performance certification criteria (adopted in § 170.315(g)) must also be certified in order for the product to be certified.

- [Quality management system \(§ 170.315\(g\)\(4\)\)](#): When a single quality management system (QMS) is used, the QMS only needs to be identified once. Otherwise, the QMS’ need to be identified for every capability to which it was applied.
- [Accessibility-centered design \(§ 170.315\(g\)\(5\)\)](#): When a single accessibility-centered design standard is used, the standard only needs to be identified once. Otherwise, the accessibility-centered design standards need to be identified for every capability to which they were

applied; or, alternatively, the developer must state that no accessibility-centered design was used.

Certification Companion Guide Changelog

The following changelog applies to:

§ 170.315(b)(4)Real-time prescription benefit

Revision History

Version #

1.0

Description of Change

Initial publication

Version Date

09-30-2025

